

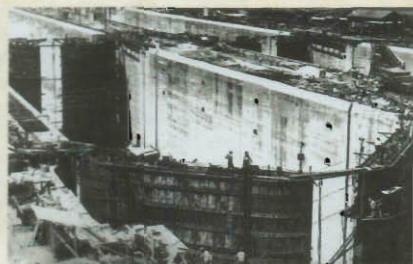
CENTRAL AMERICA, HISTORY OF



RICHLY ENDOWED WITH natural resources, Central America has had a violent history, with civil wars, revolutions, and terrible repression. The area was home to the great Maya civilization, but the Spanish arrived in the 16th century and began to conquer and settle Mexico and the lands to the southeast. As a Spanish colony, the area was called the Captaincy General of Guatemala and had its capital in Guatemala City. After gaining independence in the 1820s, the region split into separate nations ruled by a few rich families. During the 20th century, the United States often intervened in Central American politics with aid and arms.

Captaincy General

A small group of wealthy Spanish merchants born in Central America dominated the rich trade in indigo dye, and also the political life of the colony. The area was ruled by a Captain General of Guatemala and his council at Guatemala City.



Panama Canal

With military support from the USA, Panama separated from Colombia in 1903. US engineers built a great canal linking the Atlantic and the Pacific. The Panama Canal, which runs across the south of the country, opened in 1914. After this, the Panamanian economy came to depend almost entirely on the USA.



Maya

Maya civilization was at its peak in the tropical forest lowland area of Guatemala from about AD 250 to 900. Here the Maya built cities, with step pyramids. Around AD 900, the Toltecs from the north conquered the Maya. The Maya revived around 1200, but were in decline by the time of the Spanish conquest.

Maya pottery bowl

Independence

In 1821, following the example of Mexico, Central America declared independence. A federation of new states was proposed, but politicians disagreed over what form it should take. The disputes led to war and the break-up of the area into five self-governing republics in 1838.



Coffee

In the 1850s, there was a high world demand for coffee. Rich landowners began to grow coffee in large quantities, forcing local people off their land. Coffee export enabled Costa Rica and El Salvador to achieve some stability in the late 19th century, but changes in coffee prices brought problems later.

Coffee growing, El Salvador



Modern Central America

Immense differences between rich and poor, combined with the strong economic, political, and cultural influence of the United States, made Central America a turbulent region in the 20th century. Many rulers were dictators and governments changed rapidly, giving little chance of political stability. There were many revolutions, which were often suppressed with huge loss of life.



US intervention

During the 20th century, the United States was closely involved in the affairs of Central America. In 1909, the US supported a right-wing revolution in Nicaragua, and US marines occupied the country until 1933 when, after a guerilla war, Augusto Sandino (1895–1934) forced them to withdraw. Later, the US intervened to stop left-wing revolutions and to prevent the spread of communism during the Cold War. More recently, the US supported the Contras (right-wing guerillas) in Nicaragua and, in 1989, invaded Panama to oust corrupt ruler General Manuel Noriega.



Students in El Salvador erect a statue of Augusto Sandino.

Somoza family

Anastasio Somoza and his sons ruled Nicaragua from 1937–79. The economy grew under their rule, but there was widespread corruption. In 1979, an uprising led by the Sandanistas (a left-wing group named after the former socialist leader Augusto Sandino), ousted the Somozas from power.



Daniel Ortega

Socialist politician Daniel Ortega (b.1945) became the Nicaraguan head of state in 1981 and won free elections in 1984. But he failed to free his country from the conflict between the right-wing politicians backed by the USA and his own left-wing allies.



Oscar Romero

Archbishop Oscar Romero (1917–80) was head of the Catholic church in El Salvador. His reading of the Bible led him to demand better conditions for the poor. Many Catholics began to get involved in social activism in the 1970s. This annoyed the government, which employed death squads to kill priests. When Romero declared that armed struggle was the only option left, he too was shot dead.

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